

IV Others and the Human World

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a. Intertwining of natural time and historical time.

I am thrown into a nature, and nature appears not only outside of me in objects devoid of history, but is also visible at the center of subjectivity. Theoretical and practical decisions in my personal life can certainly grasp my past and my future from a distance; they can give my past, along with all of its accidents, a definite sense by following it up with a certain future of which, *après coup*, this past will be said to have been the preparation; and they can introduce a historicity into my life. But there is always something artificial to this order. I currently understand my first twenty-five years as a prolonged childhood that had to be followed by a difficult weaning process in order to arrive finally at autonomy. If I think back to those years such as I lived them and such as I now carry them with me, their happiness refuses to be explained by the protected atmosphere of the parental milieu – the world itself was more beautiful, things were more fascinating – and I can never be certain of understanding my past better than it understood itself while I lived it, nor can I ever silence its protests. My current interpretation is tied to my confidence in psychoanalysis; tomorrow, with more maturity and more insight, I will perhaps understand my past differently and I will accordingly construct it differently. In any case, I will in turn interpret my present interpretations, I will discover their latent content and, in order finally to assess their truth value, I will have to take these discoveries into account. My hold on the past and my hold on the future are precarious and my possession of my own time is always deferred until the moment when I fully understand myself, but that moment can never arrive since it would again be a moment, bordered by the horizon of a future, and would in turn require further developments in order to be understood.

My voluntary and rational life thus knows itself to be entangled with another power that prevents it from being completed and that always gives it the air of a work in progress. Natural time is always there. The transcendence of moments of time at once establishes and compromises the rationality of my history: it establishes it since it opens me up to an absolutely new future in which I will be able to reflect upon what is opaque in my present; it compromises it since from the perspective of that future I will never grasp the present that I am living with an apodictic certainty, since the lived is never fully comprehensible in this way (what I understand never precisely links up with my life), and since, in short, I am never at one with myself. Such is the fate of a being who is born, that is, a being who once and for all was given to himself as something to be understood. Since natural time remains at the center of my history, I also see myself as surrounded by it. If my first years are behind me like some unknown land, this is not through some fortuitous breakdown of memory or the lack of a complete exploration: there is nothing to be known in these unexplored lands. For example, nothing was perceived in intra-uterine life, and this is why there is nothing to remember. There was nothing but the sketch of a natural self and of a natural time. This anonymous life is merely the limit of the temporal dispersion that always threatens the historical present. To catch sight of this formless existence that precedes my history and that will draw it to a close, all I have to do is see, in myself, this time that functions by itself and that my personal life makes use of without ever fully concealing. Because I am swept along into personal existence by a time

that I do not constitute, all of my perceptions appear perspectively against a background of nature. While I am perceiving – and even without any knowledge of the organic conditions of my perception – I am conscious of integrating distracted and dispersed “consciousnesses,” namely, vision, hearing, and touch, along with their fields, which are anterior to and remain foreign to my personal life. The natural object is the trace of this generalized existence. And in some respect, each object will at first be a natural object; if it is to be able to enter into my life, it must be made of colors and of tactile and sonorous qualities.

b. How do personal acts become sedimented?

Just as nature penetrates to the center of my personal life and intertwines with it, behaviors also descend into nature and are deposited there in the form of a cultural world. Not only do I have a physical world and live surrounded by soil, air, and water, I have around me roads, plantations, villages, streets, churches, a bell, utensils, a spoon, a pipe. Each of these objects bears as an imprint the mark of the human action it serves. Each one emits an atmosphere of humanity that might be only vaguely determined (when it is a matter of some footprints in the sand), or rather highly determined (if I explore a recently evacuated house from top to bottom). Now, even if it is not surprising that sensory and perceptual functions – given that they are pre-personal – deposit a natural world in front of themselves, one might still be surprised that the spontaneous acts through which man has articulated his life themselves become sedimented on the outside and thereby lead an anonymous existence as things. The civilization in which I participate exists for me with an evidentness in the tools that it adopts. When it comes to an unknown or foreign civilization, several ways of being or living can fit over the ruins or the broken instruments that I find, or the landscape that I travel across. The cultural world is thus ambiguous, although it is already present. There is a society here that we must get to know. An Objective Spirit inhabits these vestiges and these landscapes. How is this possible?

c. How are others possible?*

In the cultural object, I experience the near presence of others under a veil of anonymity. *One* uses the pipe for smoking, the spoon for eating, or the bell for summoning, and the perception of a cultural world could be verified through the perception of a human act and of another man. How can a human action or thought be grasped in the mode of the “one,” given that it is, in principle, a first person operation and inseparable from an I? The easy response is that the indefinite pronoun is here simply a vague formula for designating a multiplicity of I's, or even an I in general. It will be said that I have the experience of a certain cultural milieu and of behaviors that correspond to it; standing before the vestiges of a lost civilization, I imagine through analogy the type of man who lived there. But it would first be necessary to know how I could have the experience of my own cultural world, of my own civilization. The response will again be that I see other men around me putting the tools that surround me to a certain use and that I interpret their behavior through analogy with my own behavior and my own inner experience, which teaches me the sense and the intention of the perceived gestures. In the end, the other person's actions would here still be understood through my own; the “one” or the “we” would still be understood through the I. But this is precisely the question: how can the word “I” be made plural? How can we form

a general idea of the I? How can I speak of another I than my own? How can I know that there are other I's? How can consciousness, which as knowledge of itself is, in principle, in the mode of the I, be grasped in the mode of the You [*To i*], and thereby in the mode of the "One"?¹

The very first cultural object, and the one by which they all exist, is the other's body as the bearer of a behavior. Whether it has to do with vestiges or with another person's body, we must ask how an object in space can become the speaking trace of an existence, and how, inversely, an intention, a thought, or a project can detach from the personal subject and become visible outside of him in his body and in the environment that he constructs. The constitution of others does not entirely clarify the constitution of society, which is not an existence shared by two or even three persons, but is rather a coexistence with an indefinite number of consciousnesses. Nevertheless, the analysis of the perception of others encounters the essential difficulty raised by the cultural world because it must resolve the paradox of a consciousness seen from the outside, the paradox of a thought that resides in the exterior and that, when compared to my own, is already without a subject and is anonymous.

d. Coexistence made possible by the discovery of perceptual consciousness.

What we have said about the body provides the beginnings of a solution to this problem. The existence of others is a difficulty for and an affront to objective thought. If events of the world are, to speak with Lachelier, an intertwining of general properties and are found at the intersection of functional relations that, in principle, allow for the completion of an analysis of these events, and if the body is in fact a region of the world – if it is that object biologists describe for me, that conjunction of processes whose analysis I find in physiological studies, and that pile of organs described by anatomy charts – then my experience could be nothing other than the confrontation between a bare consciousness and the system of objective correlations that it thinks. The other's body is no more inhabited than is my own, it is an object in front of the consciousness that thinks it or that constitutes it, and we – namely, other men and myself as an empirical being – are merely mechanisms moved by springs; the true subject has no peers. This consciousness that would be hidden in a piece of flesh and blood is the most absurd of occult qualities and my consciousness – being coextensive with what can exist for me and the correlate of the entire system of experience – can never encounter another consciousness in the other's body who would immediately make the background of his own phenomena (wholly unknown to me) appear in the world. Here there are two, and only two, modes of being: being in itself, which is the being of objects spread out in space, and being for itself, which is the being of consciousness. Now, the other would be an in-itself in front of me, and yet he would exist for himself, and in order to be perceived he would require of me a contradictory operation, since I would simultaneously have to distinguish him from me, thus placing him in the world of objects, and think of him as conscious, that is, as this type of being without an outside and without parts to which I only have access because I am this consciousness and because he who thinks and he who is thought merge in him. There is no room, then, for others and for a plurality of consciousnesses within objective thought. If I constitute the world, then I cannot conceive of another consciousness, for it too would have to have constituted the world and so, at least with regard to this

other view upon the world, I would not be constituting. Even if I succeeded in conceiving of this other consciousness as constituting the world, it is again I who would constitute it as such, and once again I would be the only constituting consciousness.

But we have in fact learned to call objective thought into doubt and we have made contact with an experience of the body and of the world beneath scientific representations of the world and the body that these representations fail to embrace. My body and the world are no longer objects coordinated with each other through functional relations of the sort established by physics. The system of experience in which they communicate is no longer spread out in front of me and watched over by a constituting consciousness. *I have* the world as an unfinished individual through my body as a power for this world; I have the position of objects through the position of my body, or inversely I have the position of my body through the position of objects, not through a logical implication, nor in the manner in which we determine an unknown size through its objective relations with given sizes, but rather through a real implication and because my body is a movement toward the world and because the world is my body's support. The ideal of objective thought – the system of experience as a bundle of physico-mathematical correlations – is grounded upon my perception of the world as an individual in harmony with itself; and when science attempts to integrate my body into the relations of the objective world, it does so because it attempts, in its own way, to express the suturing of my phenomenal body onto the primordial world. At the same time that the body withdraws from the objective world and comes to form a third genre of being between the pure subject and the object, the subject loses his purity and his transparency. Objects are in front of me, they form a certain projection of themselves upon my retina and I perceive them. It can no longer be a question of isolating, in my physiological representation of the phenomenon, the retinal images and their cerebral correlate from the total field – both actual and virtual – in which they appear. The physiological event is but the abstract outline of the perceptual event.² Moreover, we can no longer assume under the name “psychical images” some discontinuous perspectival views that would correspond to successive retinal images, or introduce in the end a “mental inspection” that restores the object over and against the distorting perspectives. We must conceive of perspectives and the point of view as our insertion in the world-as-an-individual, and we must no longer conceive of perception as a constitution of the real object, but rather as our inherence in things.

Along with sensory fields and the world as the field of all fields, consciousness discovers in itself the opacity of an originary past. If I experience this inherence of my consciousness in its body and in its mind, the perception of others and the plurality of consciousnesses no longer present any difficulty. If the perceiving subject appears (to me who is reflecting upon perception) as endowed with a primordial arrangement in relation to the world, drawing with it that bodily thing without which there would be no other things for it, then why should the other bodies that I perceive not be equally inhabited by consciousnesses? If my consciousness has a body, why would other bodies not “have” consciousnesses? This is obviously to assume that the notion of the body and the notion of consciousness have been deeply transformed. With regard to the body, and even the other's body, we must learn to distinguish it from the objective body described by physiology textbooks. For that body is not the one that could be inhabited by a consciousness. We must catch hold of the behaviors that take shape upon these visible bodies, that make their appearance there, but that are not actually contained there.³ It will never be made

clear how signification and intentionality could inhabit molecular structures or cellular masses, and here Cartesianism is correct. But then again, there is no question of such an absurd undertaking. We must recognize that the body – as a chemical structure or a collection of tissues – is formed through a process of impoverishment beginning from a primordial phenomenon of the body-for-us, of the body of human experience, or of the perceived body, which objective thought encompasses but whose completed analysis it has no need of postulating. With regard to consciousness, we must no longer conceive of it as a constituting consciousness and as a pure being-for-itself, but rather as a perceptual consciousness, as the subject of a behavior, as being in the world or existence, for only in this way will another person appear in control of his phenomenal body and receive a sort of “place.”

Given these conditions, the antinomies of objective thought disappear. Rather than defining vision as “thought that one is seeing” [*pensée de voir*] (according to Descartes's phrase),⁴ through phenomenological reflection I find vision to be the gaze gearing into the visible world, and this is why another's gaze can exist for me and why that expressive instrument that we call a face can bear an existence just as my existence is borne by the knowing apparatus that is my body. When I turn toward my perception itself and when I pass from direct perception to the thought about this perception, I reenact it, I uncover a thought older than I am at work in my perceptual organs and of which these organs are merely the trace. I understand others in the same way. Here again I have but the trace of a consciousness that escapes me in its actuality and, when my gaze crosses another, I reenact the foreign existence in a sort of reflection. But here there is nothing like a “reasoning from analogy.” Scheler said it well: reasoning by analogy presupposes what it is meant to explain.⁵ Another consciousness can only be deduced if the other person's emotional expressions and my own are compared and identified, and only if precise correlations are recognized between my gesticulations and my “psychic facts.” But the perception of others precedes and makes possible such observations, so they cannot be constitutive of it. A fifteen-month-old baby opens his mouth when I playfully take one of his fingers in my mouth and pretend to bite it. And yet, he has hardly even seen his face in a mirror and his teeth do not resemble mine. His own mouth and teeth such as he senses them from within are immediately for him the instruments for biting, and my jaw such as he sees it from the outside is for him immediately capable of the same intentions. “Biting” immediately has an intersubjective signification for him. He perceives his intentions in his body, perceives my body with his own, and thereby perceives my intentions in his body. The observed correlations between my gesticulations and those of others, and between my intentions and my gesticulations, can certainly provide a guide in the methodical knowledge of others and when direct perception fails, but they do not teach me about the existence of others. There is, between my consciousness and my body such as I live it, and between this phenomenal body and the other person's phenomenal body such as I see it from the outside, an internal relation that makes the other person appear as the completion of the system. Others can be evident because I am not transparent for myself, and because my subjectivity draws its body along behind itself.

As we said above: insofar as another person resides in the world, insofar as he is visible there and part of my field, he is never an Ego in the sense in which I am one for myself. In order to conceive of him as a genuine I, I would have to consider myself as a mere object for him, which I am prevented from doing by the knowledge that I have of myself. But if the other's body is not an object for me, nor my body an

object for him, if they are rather behaviors, then the other's positing of me does not reduce me to the status of an object in his field, and my perception of the other does not reduce him to the status of an object in my field. Another person is never fully a personal being if I am fully one myself, that is, if I grasp myself through an apodictic evidentness. But if, through reflection, I find in myself, along with the perceiving subject, a pre-personal subject given to itself, if my perceptions remain eccentric in relation to myself as the center of initiatives and judgments, or if the perceived world remains in a neutral state, neither verified as an object nor identified as a dream, then not everything that appears in the world is immediately spread out in front of me and the other's behavior can have its place in the world. This world can remain undivided between my perception and his, the perceiving self enjoys no particular privilege that renders a perceived self impossible, these two are not *cogitationes* enclosed in their immanence, but beings who are transcended by their world and who, consequently, can surely be transcended by each other. The confirmation of a foreign consciousness in front of my own would immediately turn my experience into a private spectacle, since it would no longer be coextensive with being. The other person's *cogito* strips my own *cogito* of all value and shatters the confidence I enjoyed in the solitude of having access to the only being conceivable for me, that is, being such as it is intended and constituted by me. But we have learned in individual perception not to conceive of our perspectival views as independent of each other; we know that they slip into each other and are gathered together in the thing. Similarly, we must learn to find the communication of consciousnesses in a single world. In fact, the other person is not enclosed in my perspective on the world because this perspective itself has no definite limits, because it spontaneously slips into the other's perspective, and because they are gathered together in a single world in which we all participate as anonymous subjects of perception.

e. Coexistence of psycho-physical subjects in a natural world and of men in a cultural world.

Insofar as I have sensory functions – a visual, auditory, and tactile field – I already communicate with others, themselves taken as psycho-physical subjects. My gaze falls upon a living body performing an action and the objects that surround it immediately receive a new layer of signification: they are no longer merely what I could do with them, they are also what this behavior is about to do with them. A vortex forms around the perceived body into which my world is drawn and, so to speak, sucked in: to this extent, my world is no longer merely mine, it is no longer present only to me, it is present to X, to this other behavior that begins to take shape in it. The other body is already no longer a simple fragment of the world, but rather the place of a certain elaboration and somehow a certain “view” of the world. A certain handling of things – which were until now mine alone – is taking place over there. Someone is using my familiar objects. But who? I say that it is another person, a second myself, and I primarily know this because that living body has the same structure as my own. I experience my body as the power for certain behaviors and for a certain world, and I am only given to myself as a certain hold upon the world. Now, it is precisely my body that perceives the other's body and finds there something of a miraculous extension of its own intentions, a familiar manner of handling the world. Henceforth, just as

the parts of my body together form a system, the other's body and my own are a single whole, two sides of a single phenomenon, and the anonymous existence, of which my body is continuously the trace, henceforth inhabits these two bodies simultaneously.⁶

This only establishes another living being, and not yet another man. But this foreign life, like my own life with which it communicates, is an open life. It is not reducible to a certain number of biological or sensory functions. This other life annexes natural objects by diverting them from their immediate sense, constructs tools and instruments, and projects itself into the cultural objects of its milieu. The child finds these objects around himself at birth like meteorites from another planet. He takes possession of them and learns to use them as others use them because his body schema assures the immediate correspondence of what he sees done and what he does, and because in this way the utensil takes shape as a determinate *manipulandum* and the other person takes shape as a center of human action. There is, in particular, one cultural object that will play an essential role in the perception of others: language. In the experience of dialogue, a common ground is constituted between me and another; my thought and his form a single fabric, my words and those of my interlocutor are called forth by the state of the discussion and are inserted into a shared operation of which neither of us is the creator. Here there is a being-shared-by-two, and the other person is no longer for me a simple behavior in my transcendental field, nor for that matter am I a simple behavior in his. We are, for each other, collaborators in perfect reciprocity: our perspectives slip into each other, we coexist through a single world. I am freed from myself in the present dialogue, even though the other's thoughts are certainly his own, since I do not form them, I nonetheless grasp them as soon as they are born or I even anticipate them. And even the objection raised by my interlocutor draws from me thoughts I did not know I possessed such that if I lend him thoughts, he makes me think in return. Only *après coup* – when I have withdrawn from the dialogue and I am remembering it – can I reintegrate it into my life, turn it into an episode of my private history, and only then does the other person return to his absence or, to the extent that he remains present, is the other person sensed as a threat to me.

The perception of others and the intersubjective world are only problematic for adults. The child lives in a world that he believes is immediately accessible to everyone around him. He is unaware of himself and, for that matter, of others as private subjectivities. He does not suspect that all of us, including himself, are limited to a certain point of view upon the world. This is why the child does not analyze his thoughts, why he believes in them to the extent that they appear and without attempting to tie them together, and why he does not analyze our words. He does not have the knowledge of points of view. For the child, men are blank minds directed toward a single evident world where everything takes place, even dreams (which he believes are in his room) and thought (since it is not distinguished from words). For the child, others are so many gazes inspecting things, they have an almost material existence, to the point that one child wonders how these gazes are not broken when they meet.⁷ At about the age of twelve, Piaget says, the child accomplishes the *cogito* and obtains the truths of rationalism. The child would simultaneously discover himself as a sensible consciousness and as an intellectual consciousness, as a point of view upon the world and as called upon to transcend this point of view, that is, to construct an objectivity at the level of judgment. Piaget brings the child to the age of reason as if the adult's thoughts were self-sufficient and would remove all contradictions. But in fact, children must in some

sense be correct against adults or against Piaget and, if there is to be a unique and intersubjective world for the adult, then the barbarous thoughts of the initial stage must remain like an indispensable acquisition beneath the thoughts of the adult stage. The consciousness I have of constructing an objective truth would only ever provide an objective truth for me, and my best effort at impartiality would never lead me to overcome subjectivity, as Descartes expresses so well with the hypothesis of the evil genius, if I did not have beneath my judgments the primordial certainty of touching being itself; if, prior to every voluntary *decision*, I did not already find myself *situated* in an intersubjective world; if, that is, science did not lean upon this originary $\delta\tilde{\alpha}\xi\alpha$.⁸ With the *cogito* begins the struggle between consciousnesses in which, as Hegel says, each one seeks the death of the other. For this battle to even begin, for each consciousness to even suspect the external presences that it negates, they must have a common ground and they must remember their peaceful coexistence in the world of childhood.

f. But is there a coexistence of freedoms and of I's?

But is it really the other that we reach in this way? We, in effect, level out the I and the You in an experience-shared-by-many, we introduce the impersonal into the center of subjectivity, and we erase the individuality of perspectives – but, in this general conflation, have we not caused the alter Ego to disappear along with the Ego? We said above that the two are mutually exclusive. But this is only the case because they have the same pretensions and because the alter Ego follows all the variations of the Ego: if the perceiving I is truly an I, then it cannot perceive another I; if the perceiving subject is anonymous, then the other self that he perceives is anonymous as well; and when we want to make the plurality of consciousnesses appear within this collective consciousness, we will rediscover the difficulties we thought we had avoided. I perceive the other as a behavior, for example, I perceive the other's grief or anger in his behavior, on his face and in his hands, without any borrowing from an “inner” experience of suffering or of anger and because grief and anger are variations of being in the world, undivided between body and consciousness, which settle upon the other's behavior and are visible in his phenomenal body, as well as upon my own behavior such as it is presented to me. But ultimately, the other's behavior and even the other's words are not the other himself. The other's grief or anger never has precisely the same sense for him and for me. For him, these are lived situations; for me, they are appresented. Or if I can participate in this grief or in this anger through a gesture of friendship, they remain the grief and the anger of my friend Paul: he suffers because he has lost his wife, or he is angry because his watch has been stolen; I suffer because Paul is grieving or I am angry because he is angry – the two situations are not congruent. And finally, if we undertake a shared project, this shared project is not a single project, and it is not presented to me and to Paul from the same angle; we are not equally committed to it, or at least not committed to it in the same way, from the mere fact that Paul is Paul, and I am myself. As much as our consciousnesses construct through our own situations a common situation in which they communicate, it is nevertheless from the background of his own subjectivity that each projects this “single” world.

The difficulties of perceiving others are not all the result of objective thought, and they do not all cease with the discovery of behavior, or rather, objective thought and the resulting unicity of the *cogito* are not fictions, rather, they are well-founded phenomena, and we will have to seek their foundation. The

conflict between me and others does not begin only when we attempt *to think* others, nor does it disappear if thought is reintegrated into non-thetic consciousness and unreflective life: the conflict is already there when I attempt to live another's experience [*vivre autrui*], for example, in the blindness of sacrifice. I establish a pact with the other person, and I commit to living in an inter-world where I make as much room for the other as I do for myself. But this inter-world is still my project, and it would be hypocritical to believe that I desire the other person's well-being *as my own*, since even this attachment to another's well-being still comes from me. Without reciprocity there is no alter Ego, since one person's world would thereby envelop the other's, and since one would feel alienated to the benefit of the other. This is what happens to a couple when the love is not equal on both sides: one commits to this love and stakes his life on it, the other remains free, and this love is for him but a contingent way of living. The former feels his being and his substance escaping into this freedom that remains intact in front of him. And even if the second person, through loyalty to previous promises, or through generosity, wishes to in turn reduce himself to the status of a mere phenomenon in the first person's world, to see through the other's eyes, he again achieves this through a dilation of his own life, and so he denies in principle the equivalence between others and himself that he wanted to prove as a thesis.

Coexistence must be in each case lived by each person. If neither of us is a constituting consciousness, then at the moment that we are about to communicate and to find a common world it will not be clear who communicates and for whom this world exists. And if someone does communicate with someone else, if the inter-world is not an inconceivable "in-itself," and if it must exist for both of us, then communication is once again broken and each of us operates within his private world, like two players playing on separate chessboards a hundred miles apart. Still, the players can communicate their decisions via telephone or in letters, which amounts to saying that they belong to a single world. However, strictly speaking, I do not have any common ground with other people; the positing of the other person with his world and the positing of myself with my world constitute a dilemma. Once the other has been posited, or once the other's gaze upon me has stripped me of a part of my being by inserting me into his field, then it is clear that I can only recuperate my being by forming relations with the other or by making myself freely recognized by him, and that my freedom requires that others have the same freedom.

g. The permanent truth of solipsism.*

But first we would have to know how I could posit the other. As we have explained above, insofar as I am born and insofar as I have a body and a world, I can find other behaviors in that world that intertwine with my own. But it is also the case that, insofar as I am born, and insofar as my existence finds itself already at work and knows itself as given to itself, my existence remains always on this side of the actions it wants to commit to, which are forever merely its modalities or particular cases of its insurmountable generality. This given background of existence is what the *cogito* confirms: every affirmation, every engagement, and even every negation and every doubt takes place in a previously opened field, and attests to a self in touch with itself prior to the particular acts in which it loses contact with itself. This self, who is the witness of every actual communication, and without which the communication would be unaware of itself and thus would not be communication at all, seems to

prevent any resolution of the problem of others. Here we see a lived solipsism that cannot be transcended.

Of course, I do not feel myself to be the constituting force of the natural world, nor of the cultural world: I introduce into each perception and each judgment either sensory functions or cultural arrangements that are not actually my own. Transcended on all sides by my own acts and immersed in generality, I am nevertheless the one through which these acts are lived; my first perception inaugurated an insatiable being who appropriates everything that it can encounter, to whom nothing can be purely and simply given because it inherited the world, and consequently carries in itself the plan of every possible being, and because the world has been, once and for all, imprinted upon his field of experience. The body's generality will not help us to understand how the indeclinable "I" can alienate itself to the benefit of others, since it is precisely compensated for by this other generality of my inalienable subjectivity. How could I find *elsewhere* in my perceptual field such a presence of another self to itself? Will we conclude that the existence of others is a simple fact for me? But in any case, it is a fact *for me*, it must be among my own possibilities, and it must be understood or lived in some way by me in order to count as a fact.

h. Solipsism cannot be overcome "in God."

Being thus unable to restrict solipsism from the outside, shall we attempt to overcome it from within? I can, of course, only recognize one Ego, but as a universal subject I cease being a finite myself, I become an impartial spectator for whom another person and myself as an empirical being are on an equal footing without my enjoying any privilege. It cannot be said that I am the consciousness that I discover through reflection and for whom everything is an object: my "myself" [*mon moi*] is spread out before this consciousness just like everything else, my consciousness constitutes it, it is not enclosed within it, and so it can constitute other myselfs without any difficulty. I can be conscious of others and of myself in God, and love others as myself.

– But this subjectivity we have collided with does not admit of being called God. If reflection reveals me to myself as an infinite subject, we must also recognize, at least in terms of appearances, my previous ignorance of this myself, which is more truly myself than I am. The response will be that I in fact knew of this myself, since I perceived others and myself, and since this perception is in fact only possible through this knowledge. But if I already knew this infinite subject, then all philosophical texts are useless. In fact, the truth needs to be revealed. Thus, it is this ignorant and finite self that recognized God within himself while, on the far side of phenomena, God has forever been thinking himself. It is through this shadow that the empty light comes to illuminate something, and thereby it is definitively impossible to eliminate the shadow in the light; I can never *recognize myself* as God without denying in principle what I want to prove as a thesis. I could love the other as myself in God, but it would still be necessary that my love for God not come from me, and that it is in fact, as Spinoza said, the love through which God loves himself through me. Such that, in the end there would nowhere be a love of others nor others at all, but rather a single love of self that is linked to itself beyond our lives, that has nothing to do with us, and to which we cannot gain any access. The movement of reflection and of love that leads to God actually renders impossible the very God to which it would like to lead.

i. But solitude and communication are two sides of the same phenomenon.

Thus we are brought back to solipsism, and the problem appears now in all of its difficulty. I am not God – I merely have a pretension to divinity. I escape from every engagement, and I transcend others insofar as every situation and every other person must be lived by me in order to exist in my eyes. And yet, the other has a sense for me, at least at first glance. Like polytheistic gods, I must reckon with other gods, or again, like Aristotle's God, I polarize a world that I do not create. Consciousnesses present the absurdity of a solipsism-shared-by-many, and such is the situation that must be understood. Since we live this situation, there must be some way of making it explicit. Solitude and communication must not be two terms of an alternative, but rather two moments of a single phenomenon, since other people do in fact exist for me. We must say about the experience of others what we have elsewhere said about reflection: that its object cannot absolutely escape it, since we only have a notion of the object through reflection. Reflection must, in some way, present the unreflected, for otherwise we would have nothing to set against it, and it would not become a problem for us. Similarly, my experience must present others to me in some way, since if it did not do so I would not even speak of solitude, and I would not even declare others to be inaccessible. What is initially given and true is an open reflection upon the unreflected, the reflective taking up of the unreflected – and so too is the tension of my experience toward another whose existence is uncontested on the horizon of my life, even when the knowledge I have of him is imperfect. Between these two problems, there is more than a vague analogy: in both cases the question is to know how I can reach a point outside of myself and live the unreflected as such.

j. Absolute subject and engaged subject, and birth.*

How then can I – namely, me who is perceiving and who thereby affirms myself to be a universal subject – perceive another person who immediately deprives me of this universality? The central phenomenon, which simultaneously grounds my subjectivity and my transcendence toward the other, consists in the fact that I am given to myself. *I am given*, which is to say I find myself already situated and engaged in a physical and social world; *I am given to myself*, which is to say that this situation is never concealed from me, it is never around me like some foreign necessity, and I am never actually enclosed in my situation like an object in a box. My freedom, that fundamental power I have of being the subject of all of my experiences, is not distinct from my insertion in the world. I am destined to be free, to be unable to reduce myself to any of my experiences, to maintain with regard to every factual situation a faculty of withdrawal, and this destiny was sealed the moment that my transcendental field was opened, the moment I was born as vision and as knowledge, the moment I was thrown into the world. Against the social world, I can always make use of my sensible nature, close my eyes, plug my ears, live like a stranger in society, treat others, ceremonies, and monuments like mere arrangements of colors and lights, and strip them of all human signification. Against the natural world, I can always have recourse to thinking nature and throw into doubt every perception taken in isolation. And here is the truth of solipsism. Every experience will forever appear to me as a particularity that does not exhaust the generality of my being, and I always have, as Malebranche said, some momentum for going farther. But I can only escape from being into more being; for example, I escape from society into nature, or from the real world into an imaginary that is made up of the debris of the real. The physical and social world

always functions as the stimulus of my reactions, whether they are positive or negative. I only call some such perception into question in the name of a truer one that would correct it; if I am able to deny each thing, this is always by affirming that there is something in general, and this is why we say that thought is a thinking nature, an affirmation of being through the negation of beings.

k. Suspended, not interrupted, communication.*

I can construct a solipsistic philosophy, but by doing so I presuppose a community of speaking men, and I address myself to this community. Even the “unqualified refusal to be anything whatsoever”⁹ assumes something that is refused and in relation to which the subject takes his distance. It is said that a choice must be made between others and myself. But one is chosen *over* the other, and thus both are affirmed. It is said that the other transforms me into an object and negates me, and that I transform the other into an object and negate him. But in fact, the other's gaze does not transform me into an object, and my gaze does not transform him into an object, unless both gazes draw us back into the background of our thinking nature, unless we both establish an inhuman gaze, and unless each senses his actions, not as taken up and understood, but rather as observed like the actions of an insect. This is what happens, for example, when I suffer the gaze of a stranger. But even then the objectification of each by the other's gaze is only harmful because it takes the place of a possible communication. A dog's gaze upon me hardly bothers me at all. The refusal to communicate is still a mode of communication. Protean freedom, thinking nature, the inalienable background, or the non-qualified existence, which in me and in others marks the limits of all sympathy, certainly suspends communication, but it does not annihilate it. If I must deal with a stranger who has not yet uttered a word, I might well believe that he lives in another world where my actions or thoughts are not worthy of appearing. But should he utter a word, or merely make an impatient gesture, then he already ceases to transcend me: so that is his voice, and those are his thoughts, and there is the domain I believed was inaccessible.

Each existence only definitively transcends the others when it remains idle and rests on its natural difference. Even universal meditation, which cuts the philosopher off from his nation, friends, prejudices, and empirical being – in a word, from the world – and that seems to leave him absolutely alone, is in fact action, or speech, and hence dialogue. Solipsism could only be rigorously true of someone who succeeded in tacitly observing his existence without being anything and without doing anything, which is surely impossible, since to exist is to be in the world. In his reflective retreat, the philosopher cannot avoid dragging others along with him, because he learned to forever treat them as *peers* within the obscurity of the world, and because his entire knowledge is built upon this given of opinion. Transcendental subjectivity is a revealed subjectivity, meaning that it is revealed to itself and to others, and as such transcendental subjectivity is an intersubjectivity. As soon as existence gathers itself together and engages in a behavior, it appears to perception. And like every other perception, this one affirms more things than are grasped in it: when I say that I see the ashtray and that it is over there, I presuppose a complete unfolding of the experience that would have to go on indefinitely, and I open up an entire perceptual future. Likewise, when I say that I know someone or that I like him, I am aiming at

an inexhaustible background beyond his qualities that indeed might one day shatter the image that I adopt of him. This is the price for there to be things and “others” for us, not through some illusion, but rather through a violent act that is perception itself.

l. The social, not as an object, but rather as a dimension of my being.

Thus, we must rediscover the social world, after the natural world, not as an object or a sum of objects, but as the permanent field or dimension of existence: I can certainly turn away from the social world, but I cannot cease to be situated in relation to it. Our relation to the social, like our relation to the world, is deeper than every explicit perception and deeper than every judgment. It is just as false to place us within society like an object in the midst of other objects, as it is to put society in us as an object of thought, and the error on both sides consists in treating the social as an object. We must return to the social world with which we are in contact through the simple fact of our existence, and that we inseparably bear along with us prior to every objectification. Objective and scientific consciousness of the past or of civilizations would be impossible if I did not have – through the intermediary of my society, my cultural world, and their horizons – at least a virtual communication with them, if the place of the Athenian Republic or of the Roman Empire was not somewhere marked on the borders of my own history, if they were not established there like some particular individuals to meet, indeterminate though preexisting, and if I did not find the fundamental structures of history within my own life. The social world is already there when we come to know it or when we judge it. An individualistic or sociological philosophy is a certain perception of coexistence systematized and made explicit. Prior to this coming to awareness, the social exists silently and as a solicitation.

m. The social event on the outside and on the inside.*

At the end of *Notre patrie*, Péguy discovers a buried voice that had never ceased speaking,¹⁰ just as we are sure upon waking up that objects have not ceased existing during the night, or that someone has been knocking at our door for a while. Despite their cultural, moral, vocational, and ideological differences, the Russian peasants of 1917 join the workers' struggle in Petrograd and Moscow because they sense that their lot is the same; class is lived concretely prior to being the object of a deliberate will. The social does not at first exist like an object in the third person. Wanting to treat it as an object is the common error of the curious bystander, the “great man,” and the historian. Fabrice wanted to see the battle of Waterloo as one sees a landscape, but he only found confused episodes.¹¹ Does the Emperor really see the battle on his map? But it is reduced for him to a schema, and is not without lacunae: why is this regiment not advancing; why haven't the reserves arrived? The historian, who is not involved in the battle and who sees it from all angles, who draws together a multitude of facts and who knows how the battle turned out, believes in the end that he reaches the truth of the battle. But he only presents us with a representation, he does not reach the battle itself, since, at the moment that it was taking place, the outcome was still contingent and is no longer contingent when the historian recounts the battle, since the deep causes of the defeat and the fortuitous events that allowed them to play a role were equally determining factors in the singular event of “Waterloo,” and because the historian puts the singular event back into the general sequence of the decline of the empire. The true “Waterloo” is not in what Fabrice

sees, nor in what the Emperor sees, nor in what the historian sees; it is not a determinable object. The true “Waterloo” is what *happens* on the borders of all these perspectives, and from which they are all drawn.¹²

The historian and the philosopher seek an objective definition of class or of the nation: is the nation based upon common language or upon conceptions of life? Is class based upon income level or upon one's position in the circuit of production? It is clear that none of these criteria allow us to recognize if an individual belongs to a nation or a class. In all revolutions there are some members of the privileged class who join the revolutionary class, and some oppressed individuals who remain loyal to the privileged class. And every nation has its traitors. This is because nation or class are neither fatalities that subjugate the individual from the outside, nor for that matter values that he posits from within. They are, rather, modes of coexistence that solicit him. In peaceful times, nation and class are there like *stimuli* to which I only direct distracted or confused responses; they are latent. A revolutionary situation or a situation of national danger transforms preconscious relations to class and nation that had until then been merely lived into conscious decisions; tacit commitment becomes explicit. But it appears to itself as if it pre-existed the decision.

n. The problems of transcendence.

The problem of the existential modality of the social world here meets up with all of the problems of transcendence. Whether it is a question of my body, the natural world, the past, birth or death, the question is always to know how I can be open to phenomena that transcend me and that, nevertheless, only exist to the extent that I take them up and live them, *how the presence to myself (Urpräsenz) that defines me and that conditions every external presence is simultaneously a derepresentation (Entgegenwärtigung) and throws me outside of myself.*¹³ Idealism, by making the exterior immanent in me, and realism, by subjecting me to a causal action, both falsify the relations of motivation that exist between the exterior and the interior and render this relation incomprehensible. Our individual past, for example, cannot be given to us by the actual survival of states of consciousness or of cerebral traces, nor by a consciousness of the past that would constitute it and arrive at it immediately: in both cases, we would lack the sense of the past, for the past would be for us, strictly speaking, present. If something of the past is to exist for us, then this can only be in an ambiguous presence, prior to every explicit recollection, like a field that we open onto. It must exist for us even though we do not think about it, and all of our recollections must be drawn from this opaque mass. Likewise, if I only had the world as a sum of things, and the thing as a sum of properties, I would not have any certainties, but only probabilities; no irrecusable reality, but only conditional truths. If the past and the world exist, then they must have a theoretical immanence – they can only be what I see behind myself and around myself – and an actual transcendence – they exist in my life before appearing as objects of my explicit acts. Or again, my birth or my death cannot be for me objects of thought.

Established within life, propped up by my thinking nature, placed within that transcendental field that opened with my first perception and in which every absence is merely the other side of a presence, or every silence a modality of sonorous being, I have a sort of theoretical ubiquity and eternity, I feel

destined to a flow of inexhaustible life whose beginning and whose end I cannot think, since it is still my living self who thinks them, and since thus my life always precedes itself and always survives itself. Nevertheless, this same thinking nature that fills me with being opens the world to me through a perspective, I receive along with it the feeling of my contingency, the anxiety of being transcended, such that, even if I do not think of my death, I still live within an atmosphere of death in general, there is something of an essence of death that is always on the horizon of my thoughts. Finally, just as the instant of my death is an inaccessible future for me, I am certain to never live the presence of another to himself. And nevertheless, every other person exists for me as an irrecusable style or milieu of coexistence, and my life has a social atmosphere just as it has a flavor of mortality.

o. The true transcendental is the *Ur-sprung* [springing-forth] of transcendences.

Along with the natural world and the social world, we have discovered that which is truly transcendental, which is not the collection of constitutive operations through which a transparent world, without shadows and without opacity, is spread out in front of an impartial spectator, but rather the ambiguous life where the *Ursprung* of transcendences takes place, which, through a fundamental contradiction, puts me into communication with them and on this basis makes knowledge possible.¹⁴ Perhaps the objection will be raised that a contradiction cannot be placed at the center of philosophy, and that all of our descriptions, not being ultimately thinkable, are entirely meaningless. The objection would be valid if we restricted ourselves to finding, under the name “phenomenon” or “phenomenal field,” a layer of pre-logical or magical experience. For then it would be necessary to choose between either believing the descriptions and abandoning thought, or knowing what we are saying and abandoning these descriptions. These descriptions must be the opportunity for us to define an understanding and a reflection more radical than objective thought. To phenomenology understood as a direct description, a phenomenology of phenomenology must be added. We must return to the *cogito* in order to seek there a more fundamental *Logos* than that of objective thought, one that provides objective thought with its relative justification and, at the same time, puts it in its place. On the level of being, we will never understand that the subject is simultaneously creating [*naturant*] and created [*naturé*], and simultaneously infinite and finite. But if we uncover time beneath the subject, and if we reconnect the paradox of time to the paradoxes of the body, the world, the thing, and others, then we will understand that there is nothing more to understand.